

From the Fringe to the Fore: An Algorithmic Ethnography of the Far-Right Conspiracy Theory Group QAnon

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Abstract

In this article, I examine the convergence of the socio-technological processes that enabled members of far-right conspiracy theory QAnon to expand beyond the “echo chambers” of the online fringe and incorporate themselves into mainstream discourse. Drawing on interdisciplinary research methods to focus on how technology is used in practice, I analyze QAnon’s online life through the concepts of *algorithms*, *user experiences*, and *routines*. I argue that QAnon followers’ deliberate manipulation of and incidental capitalization on algorithms gives QAnon’s content momentum that spreads information across communities; that the affordances of the user experiences of different platforms allow QAnons to curate a variety of strategies for growing their ideas and audience; and that the integration of QAnon participation into personal routines helps move the theory offline. Ultimately, a ground-up approach to digital socialization adds complexity to the analysis of echo chambers and algorithmic power.

Keywords

Conspiracy theory, Virtual ethnography, Algorithms, Fringe, Echo chambers

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In the first debate between US presidential candidates Donald Trump and Joe Biden during the 2020 national election cycle, then-president Trump refrained from openly denouncing white supremacist group the Proud Boys, instead instructing them to “stand back and stand by” (Thrush and Kanno-Youngs 2020). After the chaotic debate’s dust had settled, the top news headlines the following day centered on his comment, unpacking the Proud Boys’ history, and weighing the implications of Trump’s tacit support. As usual, I encountered the headlines in my Twitter timeline and YouTube homepage: on my personal accounts, friends, journalists, and academics criticized Trump’s remarks, providing resources to understand modern white supremacy. Then I opened my QAnon accounts. After having been active in the online community of the anti-establishment, Trump-supporting QAnon conspiracy for 4 months as a researcher, I came to expect different versions of the same stories on my separate social media. On Twitter, as I scrolled through my timeline and read through tweets listed under the trending topic “Proud Boys,” I was greeted with tweets such as these:

Which group looks more like White Supremacists? ANTIFA on the left who burn down poor, mostly minority neighborhoods or Proud Boys on the right that try to stop ANTIFA and defend neighborhoods□

MSM and Democrats HATE the Proud Boys because it’s a group of men being MEN. They would rather have our men in inclusive safe spaces where they are indoctrinated to believe masculine energy is evil.

And on my YouTube homepage, similar algorithmic trends bore out. Conservative Black intellectuals dismissed systemic racism, Black Proud Boys members defended the group, and a months-old, blatantly conspiratorial documentary exposing the “truth” behind the protest-igniting, racially motivated murder of George Floyd by Minneapolis police officers resurfaced in my feed.

Since 2016, online debates about white supremacy and police brutality have been stratified by virtual communities and algorithmic recommendations—the conventional wisdom behind echo chambers or “filter bubbles.” However, as I show here, such a description of our current cultural landscape is incomplete. To demonstrate this, I take as a case QAnon, a viral conspiracy theory that believes former president Trump had been working with military operatives to take down a Satanic, pedophilic cabal of elites. In the last 5 years, QAnon has become a vessel for conspiracy, conservatism, white nationalism, and a host of other right-wing theories and beliefs labeled “fringe” by mainstream Republicans. Yet, as much as QAnon and conservatism diverged from progressive online discourse, these former two belief

systems have been experiencing convergences themselves: QAnon has become more explicitly white nationalist, and conservatism has become more like QAnon. But how, exactly, did its life online function to bring these fringe ideas to the forefront of national dialogues, especially if it was supposed to be confined to algorithmic echo chambers?

In this article, I approach the question of mainstreaming online conspiracy theories through a virtual, algorithmically guided ethnography of QAnon's internet presence. In refiguring social technology and media as a "prism" (Bail 2021:10)—rather than an echo chamber—I trace the diverse ways in which digital technology allows for belief systems to be reinforced, reinterpreted, and propagated. To achieve this, I focus on how three socio-technological processes enabled QAnon to reinforce, reinterpret, and propagate its ideas: first, how *algorithms* cut information across communities and sustained periods of rapid growth in members by giving content momentum; second, how *user experiences* distinguished online platforms and allowed for the development of multi-pronged approaches to publicizing the movement to different groups; and third, how digital *routines* integrated QAnon's activism into people's daily lives, both deepening commitments and providing more outlets for propagation. In doing so, I also suggest some practices for virtual ethnographies that help embody the amorphous nature of the internet. Together, this approach allows me to revisit the notion of the "fringe effect"—which described how fringe actors took their beliefs to the mainstream in the early 2000s—in the age of social media (Bail 2012).

Doing Virtual Ethnography of the Online Fringe

Especially following the first "Twitter presidency," research into the politics of social media use has proliferated, as a variety of disciplines have adapted their investigative techniques to the contours of the web. Virtual ethnography has emerged as an essential and interdisciplinary mode of inquiry, drawing together media studies, computer science, and anthropology to interrogate the social dynamics of the internet as they are enabled by technological affordances and constraints (Airoldi 2018; Caliandro 2018). With studies ranging from immersive explorations of massively multiplayer online video games to cautious expeditions into the "dark web," it is essential to characterize the nature of my virtual ethnographic study in the field's rich literature (Gehl 2016; Nardi 2010). In doing so, I employ the methods of political ethnographers who have done work both on-the-ground and online, studying social movements and activists as they leverage social media to navigate political movements (Choi and Park 2014; Postill and Pink 2012). In addition, I look to the work of technologically-minded researchers who have homed in on

how the specific affordances of digital media affect modes of social engagement (Gehl 2016). In the section that follows, I develop three concepts for my virtual ethnographic study—algorithms, user experiences, and routines—that I will employ in my analysis of the online conspiracy theory QAnon.

Three Concepts for Virtual Ethnography: Algorithms, User Experiences, and Routines

While online platforms themselves may be stable, for many users, “digital experiences are enacted in volatile environments such as social networks’ feeds, social media aggregators, and changeable collections of contents” (Airoldi 2018, 662). These “volatile environments” gain coherence for the user in part due to the algorithmic systems that organize content, user experiences that determine participation in environments, and routines through which the user incorporates the internet into daily life. Thus, when conducting ethnographies of such spaces, it is necessary to consider how the digital world logically structures itself, how that structure is manipulated by users, and how that structure is inserted into the user’s offline world—in other words: algorithms, user experiences, and routines. In developing these concepts, this section articulates a multivalent approach to embody and inhabit online spaces that foregrounds how people use digital devices (Hine 2000, 19–54).

In theory, algorithms are no more than “a process or set of rules to be followed in calculations or other problem-solving operations” (Oxford Languages 2020). However, in practice, Barocas, Hood, and Ziewitz (2013) termed algorithms a “modern myth,” referring to a set of opaque but salient rules that govern people’s experiences with technology (p. 1). Far from remaining computational tools, algorithms are popularly understood as the arbiters of truth, order, and virality online. Popular press articles such as “Facebook Audit Exposes Algorithm Biases in Policing Speech” or “Meet the Secret Algorithm That’s Keeping Students Out of College” point to their preponderance in discussions of perennial social issues (Leetaru 2020; Simonite 2020). O’Neil (2018) summarizes algorithms as “opinion[s] embedded in math”: after consuming mass amounts of social data, algorithms calculate an opinion about what a given technology should do, be that recommending a new YouTube video or ranking Google search results. Algorithms therefore form the basis of the logic of the user experience, the mathematical computation that says, “this person wants to watch conspiracy videos.” An algorithm’s opinions—about who wants to watch what videos, about what content most accurately represents a given news story, about what images are most suitable for a search result—are thus social theories.

Possessing theories about the social world, algorithms become legible as both texts and weapons—we can read algorithms as reflections of cultural stereotypes (e.g., the algorithm is a text representing racist ideas about Black women by associating images of them with negatively connotated search terms), but we can also see them as actionable, possessing the power to inflict social harm (e.g., the Facebook group recommendation algorithm is a weapon radicalizing target demographics) (Edwards and Veale 2017; Horwitz and Seetharaman 2020; Noble 2018; Seaver 2019). Oftentimes, the algorithm's opinions reflect the logic, intentions, ethics, and profit margins of a tech company's CEO or employees (Mittelstadt 2016; Seaver 2019). And, despite having monumental effects on how information and experience flow through our society, these proprietary algorithms “carry out their business in the dark” (O’Neil 2016: Chapter 10). There are computational approaches to “auditing” algorithms for bias, but what is missing from these investigations is frequently the human component: how these algorithms manifest themselves in people's experiences of their devices is often assumed rather than demonstrated (Eslami et al. 2015; Hamilton et al. 2014; Rader and Gray 2015). Precisely because the logical, technological, and social principles which organize the internet remain opaque, I propose algorithms—in their mythical form—as a necessary concept for understanding how information and experience flow to users. In ethnography, I do not suggest that ethnographers need to become computer scientists, reverse engineering the mechanics of a given digital platform, but to critically become users, approaching the algorithms as any other user could.

User experiences foreground how people interact with the internet and their devices. User experiences refer to the actual experience that a user has on their device, such as uploading videos, liking, or sharing content. Frequently, user experiences are studied in isolation by the developers of technology in order to improve them. However, ethnographers have increasingly become interested in the ways that individuals interact with their devices, interrogating how digital devices' affordances both limit certain forms of social interaction and enable others (Choi and Park 2014; Gehl 2016). For example, an understanding of Twitter's promotional processes—such as mass retweeting or the deliberate use of specific hashtags—allow users greater opportunities for advertising political ideas and creating discursive political arenas, while Twitter's anonymity and 280 character limit might prevent personal, nuanced discussions (Bail 2021, 123–127; Bonilla and Rosa 2015; Choi and Park 2014). Users of these sites have been termed “prosumers,” simultaneously creating and consuming content within the confines of these affordances (Ritzer and Jurgenson 2010). Analysis of their social practices, then, can be contextualized with digital methods that examine more deeply the features of a given platform (Caliandro 2018).

Meanwhile, routines move beyond the digital interface to ask more broadly how these devices are brought into people's lives offline. I borrow the term "routine" from Postill and Pink's (2012) ethnography, where they described how one researcher incorporated phone use into habits, such as when "catching up" on news online. For these researchers, routines were important ways of keeping in mind the "material world" as digital habits and socialization were incorporated into it, but they also provided an embodied way of understanding how people inhabit the "messy web" of online life. Moreover, routines highlight that behind every digital experience is a person—every tweet is made by someone (or someone's bot) and then seen by someone else. This conceptual orientation follows the lead of researchers who have asked for destabilization of the offline/online distinction, focusing on internet ethnographies that track how experiences travel across the messy web of different networked platforms and then into people's daily lives (Hine 2000, 54; Leander and McKim 2003; Postill and Pink 2012). Doubtless, contemporary social issues such as the Black Lives Matter movement have demonstrated how social media has the capacity not just for discursive changes but material changes, effects on both how people think and then how they act upon these thoughts in their offline lives (Bonilla and Rosa 2015; Carney 2016).

While algorithms, user experiences, and an overuse of digital devices in routines have been characterized as socially dangerous, recent field experiments have called into question the fetishization of digital technology's rippling social effects, citing scandals such as Cambridge Analytica—in which private Facebook data were leveraged in a targeted advertising campaign—as exaggerated (Bail 2021). Such work moves beyond algorithmic omnipotence, echo chambers, and filter bubbles to see social media as a "prism that refracts our identities—leaving us with a distorted understanding of each other, and ourselves" (Bail 2021:10). It is not simply the technology that is dangerous but how we use it. Useful in this refiguring of social media is Seaver's (2017) distinct understandings of algorithms: algorithms *in* culture and algorithms *as* culture. In the former characterization, Seaver describes algorithms as rocks in a stream: "the rock is not part of the stream, though the stream may jostle and erode it and the rock may produce ripples and eddies in the stream," while in the latter characterization, algorithms "are rather just more water" (2017, 4–5). Studying an algorithm *in* culture may allow the researcher to better track how algorithms shape society and how society shapes algorithms. Meanwhile, algorithms *as* culture more intimately positions algorithms within cultural milieus, and it asks the researcher to focus on the embedded, inseparable nature of algorithms (and their creators) within culture. However, the concepts of user experiences

and routines demonstrate that, without human interaction, algorithms are impotent. Thus, if—taken together—algorithms, user experiences, and routines describe social technology: social technology is *in* society, refracting identities to distort the world with rippling effects, but it is also itself society, reflecting ways that people have always worked to understand and participate in the world. The emphasis is placed both on how the technology functions and how the technology is used.

To think through one example, the Facebook “group suggestion” technology has been criticized for its potentially radicalizing effects (Horwitz and Seetharaman 2020). It suggests groups for users to join, sometimes creating a link between seemingly disparate groups with popular demographic overlaps, such as exposing religious Facebook users to New Age conspiracy theories. In this way, the technology is a rock in the stream, pushing like-minded individuals into close-knit groups where they feed on each other’s shared prejudices. The Facebook technology is *also* the stream: it reflects the ways that people have always self-segregated and continues a human tradition of tribalizing tastes, prejudices, and geographies. More importantly, the algorithm which powers this technology—forming an opinion on group categories based on aggregate personal data—is made through interaction: users experience the algorithm in unique ways that can only be understood by studying how they interact with Facebook and integrate Facebook into their daily lives, rendering the technology social. From my experience with Facebook, as a prismatic social technology, the group suggestion feature does not unilaterally radicalize people but may put people into groups with both unexpected or expected political leanings, at times challenging people’s identities and at other times reinforcing them. Such a social technology makes itself a candidate for ethnographic inquiry: observing and participating in Facebook might allow the researcher to access radical communities, understand how the technology radicalizes, and understand how radicalization itself operates—social technology as tool, object, and theory. By framing the Facebook group suggestion technology as social technology, driven by user interaction, we can ask: how do people use Facebook, and how does Facebook use people?

This article sits at the intersections of technologically-minded analysis of algorithms and user experiences—both of which reflect and refract human identities based on how individuals interact with them—and a more explicitly ethnographic approach to routines, examining how the social effects of algorithms and user experiences are interpellated into daily life. It builds on the work of scholars of social media, virtual ethnography, and political media and polarization to approach the fringe world of an online conspiracy theory.

The Case: QAnon

QAnon began on the infamous alt-right internet forum 4chan, a site dedicated to anonymous free speech that has cultivated a community of far-right members engaged in frequently misogynistic, racist, or otherwise bigoted trolling and discussion (Coaston 2018). While QAnon's main hub of activity has shifted over its initial inception in 2017, the basic premise has remained the same: An anonymous military operative, codenamed "Q," posts coded messages—or "drops"—to select internet forums. Users decode these messages, which point to expansive government corruption, as part of an effort to expose the "truth" to the world, acting as the messengers of Q's word. This "truth" argues that the world is being run by an elite group of Satanic pedophiles installed in the highest levels of financial, governmental, and entertainment sectors, and that former president Donald Trump is working to take down this cabal with the aid of the military. The spread of online information related to Q's messages thus formed the backbone of QAnon's existence. While the conspiracy theory persists despite Trump's loss at the polls, the research presented here focuses on QAnon prior to inauguration day 2021.

Methods

I employed a mixed-methods approach to my ethnography of QAnon, combining an expansive, multi-sited virtual ethnography with in-depth interviews and quantitative content analysis. While this article focuses primarily on the data gathered during the virtual ethnography, I use interview data and quantitative data to flesh out the ethnographic observations.

I began background research on QAnon in October of 2019, about 6 months before I would begin creating accounts to prepare for the virtual ethnography. Prior to the pandemic, I had begun meeting with and talking to a prominent supporter from my city, who became a close informant, giving me information as to which accounts to follow online and which websites to visit. Then, in the following spring, I began creating accounts designed for the purpose of studying QAnon. I created a primary email account that I then used to sign up for most major (and fringe) social media platforms, and this account was housed on its own device so as to isolate the effects of algorithms as best as I could (Sandvig et al. 2014). I created other accounts with other burner email addresses, which I used on different laptops and phones, that were not as developed and frequently used as the original QAnon account but which allowed me to start fresh in entering QAnon. The goal of having many different accounts—as well as having one dedicated device to one account—was to be able to get different perspectives on the QAnon online

community and algorithmic effects by watching different videos, following different users, and joining different groups.

On these accounts, I observed the QAnon community, watching YouTube, TikTok, and Bitchute videos, reading through social media platforms Parler, Twitter, Facebook, 8kun, WeGo.Social, Voat, and Gab, and “researching” QAnon on a variety of news sites and the QAnon home for research, the now-defunct qmap.pub. Qmap.pub was used by QAnons to aggregate all of the posts from Q, as well as much of the accompanying analysis that came with their decoding. Because QAnons insist upon doing their own research, if I ever had questions about political events or QAnon theories, I looked them up and investigated them on the device dedicated to QAnon (which mostly just resulted in more conservative news coming to that phone). Thus, the multi-sited virtual ethnography was united by my use of a dedicated device for QAnon which housed all of my Q-related activity and research, just as much as it was united by my presence and actions on that device—the two constants. Participation in these spaces raise questions of ethics and positionality: while I participated much as any other user would (joining groups, liking videos, etc.), I identified myself as a researcher at all times, expressing my sympathies to the movement while being candid about my political beliefs when asked. This article labels certain beliefs as fringe—such as belief in white supremacy or widespread child trafficking—but I take QAnons’ beliefs at face value as often as I can, noting when things are demonstrably false only insofar as it is pertinent to analysis.¹

I collected ethnographic data daily over the course of 4 months, from June to September 2020. This data included field notes describing what I saw and did online, conversations with informants in the field, and downloaded, screenshotted, or otherwise archived online material. This online immersion provided the basis for analysis of how people interact with algorithms and capitalize on user experiences. When I began collecting data, the United States was just beginning to realize the scope and scale of the COVID-19 pandemic, an event paired with a dramatic increase in followers of QAnon (Labbe et al. 2020), which also signaled a shift in QAnon’s major focus. While QAnon had always been tied to the conservative news cycle, I witnessed an expansion of the community to more directly engage with the COVID-19 pandemic, the Black Lives Matter movement, and the upcoming November election. Ultimately, I present data from the height of QAnon’s presence on the internet, when it took hold as a political force in the United States due to the anxieties revealed by a number of national and international flashpoints.

I chose to conduct in-depth interviews with QAnons because members are notoriously private about their lives offline and because their online presence

can misrepresent their actual lived experiences (Gehl 2016). Interviews became important for understanding informants' offline lifestyles, especially their routines. I conducted 14 semi-structured audio interviews (8 women and 6 men) and 16 text interviews (5 women and 11 men), later coded using an open coding technique. A total of 27 participants were recruited via Twitter, and the remaining three came from YouTube, TikTok, and Facebook. Most people responded to direct messages about their posted content, while others reached out to posts that I had made identifying myself as a researcher. Instead of snowball sampling, I used Twitter's public "following/followers" information (and comparable features on other platforms) to locate members of the same digital social network. I performed a variety of content analyses on the material that I found online, using my cyberethnography as a guide for where to look. Using the R programming language package *rtweet*, I downloaded 371,591 unique tweets and 131,477 completed user bios, and then generated social networks of QAnon based on user interactions (Kearney 2019; R Core Team 2020). Thus, my three methods enabled a comprehensive overview of the personal lives of QAnon supporters, the type of content they produce, and the type of content they consume.

Bringing the Fringe to the Fore

The "fringe effect," a theory conceptualized in response to the rise of anti-Muslim sentiment following the attack on the World Trade Center, posits that fringe ideas often gain national prominence when they are acknowledged by popular, mainstream news sources (Bail 2012). Following the notion that "any press is good press," these fringe organizations' fear and anger were amplified by traditional news outlets, shaping mainstream discourse about Muslims. However, the social media landscape has allowed for the elevation of once-fringe and radical ideas to the level of national prominence, with figures like Alex Jones establishing entire alternative news networks that boast sizeable audiences and platform conspiracy theorists (Southern Poverty Law Center 2020). Promoters of these conspiracy theories, which have been a long-standing feature of American identity and discourse (Hofstadter [1964] 2012; Walker 2014), have increasingly leveraged the open-access nature of the internet to rival the power of epistemic authorities (Stano 2020). Together, these trends indicate that national truth-making is changing, as traditional mainstream media must contend with its alternates, including both fringe news networks and social media. Should these online platforms generate enough attention themselves, then acephalous, online social movements should likewise be able to bring fringe ideas forward, bypassing the need for attention from mainstream media while simultaneously demanding it.

QAnon has been described as a “radically participatory” conspiracy theory due to the emphasis it places on an active engagement with social media and independent research (Zuckerman 2019). Following Q’s messages, members are encouraged and expected to share information as much as possible, to promote Q’s ideas, and to formulate theories and exchange information with each other. This radical participation is enabled by social technology that shapes and is shaped by the movement. While there are large, outstanding questions about online conspiracies that this paper touches upon—how do people come to believe in them; what social, economic, and political structures and contexts have influenced their development; or what organizations have leveraged them for their own purposes—this article focuses on the specifically technological processes through which the online conspiracy theory QAnon infiltrated the mainstream, allowing followers new and old to reinforce, reinterpret, and propagate their beliefs. First, I will discuss algorithms, which have allowed members to seamlessly bring fringe information across the internet and generated the momentum needed to push fringe ideas forward. Second, I will discuss user experiences, which have distinguished different platforms, apps, and social technologies broadly based on how users have engaged with them, enabling a multi-pronged information campaign. Third, I will discuss routines, which demonstrate how people have taken QAnon from online forums to their offline lives. At each point, it is critical to remember that two processes are occurring: first, QAnon is itself incorporating more fringe beliefs as it incorporates more fringe members; and second, QAnon is then bringing these fringe beliefs to mainstream attention.

Algorithms: Crossing Communities and Content Momentum

In early July, a Reddit user posted a screenshot of cabinets being sold via the online vendor Wayfair to a forum dedicated to conspiracies with the caption,

Is it possible Wayfair involved in Human trafficking with their WFX Utility collection? Or are these just extremely overpriced cabinets? (Note the names of the cabinets) this makes me sick to my stomach if it’s true).

The cabinets—large, grey, industrial—did not seem to warrant their \$10,000 price tags, and the names for each cabinet—Neriah, Yaritzah, Samiyah—were strangely playful, personal choices for products that were intended for corporate consumption. The conspiracy theory quickly moved from Reddit to Facebook, Twitter, and TikTok via screenshots of the original post. Users began digging, trying to find some explanation for these cabinets

by way of customer support emails, Google searches, and conjecture. Some stumbled upon news stories with missing children whose names matched the products, while others found that the products' SKUs, if searched on the right engine, would bring up pictures of children. I first saw this flurry of activity on my personal Twitter timeline, where friends of mine—young college students with progressive politics—were liking or retweeting these would-be citizen journalists, and when I clicked on the “Wayfair” trend in Twitter’s user interface, I was shocked by the sudden convergence of my conspiratorial research with my separate, personal social media: QAnon had arrived on my personal timeline.

In replies, debunkers would point out that named children had been found, often with benign reasons for their disappearance, and that the particular search engine accessed the archives of a modeling company, resulting in child models regardless of search terms. While the prices were still high and the names were still odd, there was a large enough information vacuum that jumping immediately to human trafficking felt premature. Within a day, my friends had stopped talking about it altogether—but QAnon had not. Instead, QAnons were in the replies of tweets all across the site, using this small moment of suspicion to lock in new followers. Three years into its existence, QAnon had assembled enough resources to make a case for its belief in widespread child trafficking, and so members rapidly provided these suspicious, incidental Wayfair conspiracy theorists with all the necessary videos and websites to get them involved in QAnon. The explosion of so-called WayfairGate revealed two things: first, there may have been more overlap with QAnons and my friends than I had anticipated. Tweets like, “This whole focus on ‘Wayfair’ is so no one realizes Amazon is doing the same thing. . .” or, “The only reason you think [WayfairGate is not real] is because highly politicized corporate media invested a lot of resources to deter you from looking into it” point to a shared distrust in mainstream media and corporations. Second, the convergence of these two communities demonstrated how, despite so-called echo chambers, people from radically different online communities could find themselves participating in shared discourse as the algorithm stitched together disparate communities under one trend. Together, any overlap—semantic, ideological, or topical—could result in conspiracy expanding beyond its insular spaces.

This overlap was not accidental. On Twitter, QAnons worked to embed themselves in popular spaces, aware of how they could utilize algorithms to grant their content a momentum online. By manufacturing interest through likes, retweets, shares, and views (sometimes with the assistance of outside actors; Menn 2020), QAnons made intriguing or topical hashtags (e.g., DarkToLight, SaveTheChildren, and WayfairGate), the battleground for both

their movement's ideology and their own individual status within the community, as is reflected in the promotional fervor of this tweet:

I love it when I see a fellow Patriot tweet they are 30 away from hitting their goal of 100 followers and when I click on profile they are over 15K ! This Digital Army is GROWING! Lets [sic] get everyone's accounts there! Add all the Patriots that like and comment. LET'S GO SOLDIERS!

These algorithmic tactics extend beyond Twitter. On Facebook, because of the high number of QAnon followers in groups dedicated to conservatism, religion, or the military, such groups became algorithmically linked to one another via the aforementioned group suggestion algorithm. Within these non-QAnon groups, it was also possible for the many ardent QAnons to promote their content and, using explicit or implicit conspiratorial messaging, expose people to QAnon beliefs that they would not be able to distinguish from Republican or Christian beliefs. On Instagram, the #SaveTheChildren campaign reached "influencers," often in the fitness and wellness communities, who would then create a link between their followers—routinely women—and the QAnon accounts also promoting #SaveTheChildren (Tiffany 2020). TikTok's infinite scroll of algorithmically-suggested videos, which were highly responsive to user preferences expressed through likes and watch time, perpetually adapted to give users more content that was similar to their previous content, so liking any QAnon video—such as one disguised as a "true crime" narrative—opened the door to more rapid-fire conspiracy content. Based on my time on the app, TikTok also routinely tries to show users videos that have very few views, are popular among other users, or that are outside of the user's preferences, which can result in fringe accounts suddenly developing massive followings, people being presented with popular misinformation that looks more legitimate due to its popularity, or people being randomly exposed to QAnon without any context. YouTube's video recommendations had similar results.

On Etsy, the online retailer known as a forum for selling artisan-crafted products, there were a few days where the top trending search term was "SaveTheChildren," with merchandise featuring QAnon logos and symbols. And one interviewee reported being recommended QAnon books via Amazon, likely due to her and her husband's interests in spirituality and American history. Something of an algorithmic syncretism allowed QAnon beliefs to be associated with overlapping demographics, news stories, or interests, as conspiracy Facebook groups slowly merged populations with conservative Facebook groups. This algorithmic syncretism reflects the syncretic nature of QAnon's wide-reaching, adaptable belief system that flexed

with its desire to gather more followers. In these cases, QAnons—once hyperaware of how algorithms would allow them to break out of echo chambers and influence others—were unaware of how algorithms were making their own beliefs more fringe. Just as the fringe QAnon conspiracy could expand into mainstream discourse, other fringe groups could expand into QAnon.

The Proud Boys case explained at the opening of this article is reflective of how fringe beliefs could integrate themselves into QAnon. Because QAnon's online presence was perpetually being connected to the worlds of conservatism, militia movements, and white nationalism, when Trump refused to denounce the Proud Boys, the many worlds came to a head, allowing what had always been QAnon's peripheral or unspoken white nationalism to integrate itself into the QAnon movement, disguising itself with appeals to militia movements and Republican values. White nationalism—linked to QAnon—could leverage QAnon's content-creating and algorithm-capitalizing online network to link itself to more mainstream discourse. However, this is not to say that algorithms did this without influence: it was by design that white nationalists promoted their ideas through QAnon—or QAnons promoted their ideas through militia movements—using shared terminology and sending content across different online communities to enable these algorithmic developments.

In each of these cases, QAnons took advantage of algorithmic processes to dictate discussions online: with hashtags and trends on sites like Twitter or TikTok, QAnons provided explanations that were, on the surface, often largely apolitical besides being anti-corporate or anti-establishment. Once a user clicked on a user profile, replies, or related content, they ran the risk of being exposed to the full political mission of QAnon. This is how many popular QAnon videos began on YouTube: they would address common political topics, posing questions about human trafficking, immigration, or police abolition—which would algorithmically get their videos placed in the same categories as more mainstream news or included in search results—and then make the thematic turn indicative of a conspiracy theory: "What if I told you," one video asked, "there was a reason for it all? What if I told you it was done on purpose?" It was frequently at this turn that the most fringe ideas could be wrapped into the theory itself: primed with fear and curiosity, QAnons with specific fringe beliefs could begin explaining how Jewish families, migrants, or Black people were responsible for these problems, generating a tacit Anti-Semitism, xenophobia, or white supremacy masked by the idealism of "just wanting to know the truth."

These examples demonstrate the prismatic nature of algorithms within social technology: in the Proud Boys example, algorithms allowed for the reinterpretation of a white nationalist group through the lens of Second Amendment

rights and a disavowal of critical race theory. This reinforced QAnons' attachment to their ideals, now incorporating the Proud Boys into their worldview and assisting the Proud Boys in propagating their message. WayfairGate broke out of echo chambers, unlike the Proud Boys, and while the smaller conspiracy theory certainly reinforced QAnons' beliefs, it also assisted them in propagating them elsewhere, providing people the resources to reinterpret the faux scandal through the lens of QAnon (along with anti-corporatism).

There is a limit to this algorithmic approach when one considers how fraught these online experiences could be. My attempts to establish multiple accounts to navigate different worlds of QAnon felt inauthentic—I had a target, no matter how hard I tried not to. In interfaces with hundreds of potential navigable paths at any given moment, any attempt to simulate the serendipity of algorithms becomes performative: when YouTube recommendeds both a conspiracy video and video of a dog playing with a toddler, how can I assume which one an informant would choose? In this respect, algorithms were helpful in guiding research: they were infinite portals to more content, as I could continuously find YouTube videos to watch or Facebook groups to join, but interactions with algorithms are not homogenous nor predictable. While I knew that after following a self-proclaimed #DigitalWarrior would result in three associated #DigitalWarrior Twitter accounts being suggested to me, I could never know what would compel each QAnon to follow those suggested accounts.

Despite my inability to authentically experience algorithms as a curious, unaware party, I will readily admit that I watched some compelling QAnon videos, ones that struck at my own fears about corporatization and government corruption. Had the lateral movement not been toward QAnon but to a more progressive anti-establishment movement, it is easy to imagine myself going deeper down the rabbit hole, reiterating my political views and reinterpreting them in this new frame. This is ultimately indicative of the fact that algorithms will have many opinions, and while they may push us to unexpected, fringe beliefs, we will also use algorithms to navigate toward a belief that reflects some part of ourselves—and these two processes are not necessarily distinct. As they work to propagate out linked content, algorithms are always giving people the chance to both reinterpret and reinforce their beliefs—to refract and to reflect.

User Experiences: Distinguishing and Decontextualizing Platforms in Practice

Lying on a couch in her family home, a teenage girl wrestled with one of her many German Shepherds, pulling its tongue away from her face. In her next TikTok video, the girl filmed herself patting the dog's stomach. Scrolling

through the earliest videos on her account, it is clear she was experimenting with comedic sketches, gossip updates, and of course, dog videos, trying her hand at the viral trends that had skyrocketed other content creators to stardom. At times, she earned a modest few thousand views, but as I scrolled closer to her latest posts, those numbers jumped into the tens and hundreds of thousands: she had begun posting about QAnon. In short vlogs, she theorized about the United States' hyperfixation on race and walked viewers through documentary-style decoding of WikiLeaks emails associated with Pizzagate, an earlier conspiracy theory. She wasn't alone in her recent conspiratorial musings: the 2016 Pizzagate conspiracy—one that alleges a D.C. pizza shop was the hub of a Democrat-owned child sex ring—experienced a resurgence on TikTok among a new audience of young, intrepid investigators who, like this girl, found that their home footage couldn't rival the allure of political intrigue.

To be certain, algorithms helped fuel the rise of QAnon TikTok. TikTok aggregates content based on identifiers such as hashtags or reproducible audio files, so people posting about QAnon could use the proper hashtags, or borrow other popular ones, to cross communities and give their content momentum: if someone liked a video from a QAnon content creator, they were immediately susceptible to more videos from that creator or from whichever hashtag that creator used. And while these algorithmically determined user experiences necessarily dictate, in part, how content travels across the web, in this section, we can examine user experiences from more basic affordances, considering what users are capable of creating regardless of the algorithm's spreading effects. The essential features of these communication platforms—as well as the platforms' demographics—allow them to be distinguished from one another, thus also distinguishing how they contribute to QAnon's mainstreaming powers. Sharing across platforms also enables these platforms to be decontextualized, allowing fringe beliefs to be hidden by way of reproduction.

In posting to TikTok, the girl was limited to short, minute-long videos, but these videos still allowed her to share images, text, and audio from other sources by using the app's built-in editing tools. Due to these time limits, QAnon was different on TikTok than it was on other apps: while YouTube contained long, winding documentaries that could span hours and brought in extensive footage from other sources, TikTok contained exacting videos that pushed out attention-grabbing headlines and did what conspiracy theories do best: leave viewers wanting more. Naturally, some content creators created multi-part series, and over the course of one account, one might find hours' worth of content that created a larger story, but for many people, QAnon on TikTok opened the door to a conversation—or, in QAnon's terms, it was the

start of the rabbit hole. TikTok's youthful culture—mostly dedicated to dance and music—meant that even short jokes became tactics for propagation. One user danced to NSYNC's 2005 hit song, "Bye Bye Bye" in front of an image of a news article with the headline "Guantanamo Bay Ordered to Prepare For High-Level American Prisoners," suggesting that top Democrats (like Hillary Clinton) were soon to be arrested. She was part of a growing industry of QAnons who would repurpose popular meme formats, reimagining a harrowing conspiracy about Satanic pedophiles as a quirky song or joke. QAnon on TikTok further appealed to younger people through the suggestion of there being "something else out there"—such promotional videos were often algorithmically paired with videos about urban legends or mysteries. One user even documented her estrangement from her progressive parents due to her belief in QAnon, turning a story of getting sucked into a conspiracy theory into the more relatable theme of youthful rebellion. With a young audience, playful memes, political drama, and teenaged rebellion worked perfectly with the app's short-form content.

While QAnon on TikTok made for enrapturing introductions to the conspiracy theory, and QAnon on YouTube was designed for binge-watching documentaries that went into theories in-depth (taking viewers deeper into the rabbit hole), Twitter and Facebook, along with less popular but less moderated sites such as Voat, Gab, and Parler, were effective at pegging QAnon to the news, disseminating information from other sites, and enabling interpersonal conversations. Nearly all of my informants claimed to get most of their news from social media, along with some right-wing cable outlets such as *Fox News* and *One America News Network* or online newspapers such as *Breitbart* and *The Epoch Times*. Frequently, clips or articles from these right-wing sources would be posted to these platforms, where users could scroll through their timelines to get up to date with the latest news. In QAnon-specific spaces, like Facebook groups or Voat, Gab, and Parler, people could expect to see these news articles reinterpreted by fellow QAnons, allowing for all news to be remade in the worldview of QAnon. Here it has to be acknowledged once again that the conversion to QAnon was not, for many, a radical departure but a lateral reinterpretation: *Fox News* regularly took stances that aligned with QAnon, questioning the efficacy of vaccines, the legitimacy of the presidential election, or the motives of Black Lives Matter protests, and with QAnon's tactful interpretations, it was no stretch of the imagination for many followers to conclude that a global cabal including billionaires Bill Gates and George Soros or Democratic politicians Hillary Clinton and Barack Obama were manufacturing these problems.

The taken-for-granted power of the screenshot dominated QAnon's reinterpretations and allowed for the decontextualization of fringe content.

Because Q's messages were hosted on less accessible fringe platforms such as 4chan, 8chan, and 8kun, it was vital that QAnons could post screenshots of Q's messages in the comments of a Facebook news article or Twitter thread—another way of linking Q to popular news. Outside of QAnon-specific spaces, similar hyperlinking and screenshotting tactics allowed QAnons to fill the replies or comments of news articles with Q-content. The rapidity and ease with which text could be screenshotted, shared, or copy-and-pasted made text and image-based platforms like Twitter and Facebook prime candidates for voluminous promotional strategies that laid out a hodgepodge of arguments taken from other social media accounts, 8kun, or news headlines, selectively presenting information that was best at convincing others. The decontextualizing effects of screenshots meant that headlines appeared without articles or 8kun posts appeared without the requisite pornography and Nazism one views if they visit the site. In this way, conspiracy theories that had originated in anti-Semitic or white supremacist debates emerged as constituent parts of QAnon, removed and repackaged to suit different platforms and their respective demographics.

These text-based sites also allowed for interpersonal conversations—publicly or in private messages—that enabled the working out of ideas while growing closer to other members of QAnon. The simple notions of friending and following people and then seeing them in Facebook groups or messaging them on Twitter allowed QAnons to feel connected and keep in touch, either anonymously—usually on Twitter—or as their full selves—usually on Facebook. Unlike on YouTube or TikTok where views generated a social hierarchy that encouraged perpetual QAnon research and promotion, Facebook and Twitter were littered with small posts where people talked about themselves in addition to their thoughts on Q. In one Facebook group, a member posed the question, “Is it okay to share all the best/worst Q related pickup lines here?”, contributing “My plan is to bed you. You have to believe in the plan” and “My turn-ons include popcorn, and the smell of napalm in the morning.” In little exchanges like these, QAnon rhetoric moved beyond promotional strategies and became part of people's casual lives on the internet.

As a quick example of both how different features within sites afforded different uses of the site as well as how quantitative data can be rendered more legible by qualitative work, I used network data from Twitter to determine the most central “nodes” in a sample of 50,000 QAnon accounts. For “mentions” (the act of tweeting *at* another person), the most frequently “mentioned” nodes were Donald Trump's personal account, Trump's presidential account, General Mike Flynn, and Donald Trump Jr.—all of whom might be considered allies of QAnon—in addition to the accounts of enemies, such as

Joe Biden, YouTube, and Twitter CEO Jack Dorsey (tech companies had attracted their ire through censorship). The most frequently retweeted or quote tweeted accounts were QAnon promoters. If one examines the tweets, it is evident that QAnons use the high status of people like Trump to share their beliefs in the replies of tweets, and they feel connected to Trump and others by communicating “directly” with them. Meanwhile, when retweeting QAnon promoters or quote tweeting them to add more content, QAnons are doing less to promote QAnon to others and more to keep the conversation within QAnon going, generating something of a public opinion by adding to and reinforcing points made by other QAnons.

Each technology’s features determined how the platform was able to be used by QAnons, and where platforms could not be distinguished by features, they could regularly be distinguished by demographics. TikTok, Instagram, and YouTube’s video formats were perfect for enrapturing messages; Etsy, Patreon, Amazon, and PayPal helped fund independent QAnon creators who could make something of a living off of the movement; and sites like Facebook, Twitter, Parler, Voat, and Gab allowed for interpersonal conversations and discussions about the news. While TikTok appealed to younger audiences and Facebook to older, within each of these, different demographic niches were carved out. The urban legends-seeking teenagers of TikTok did not necessarily watch the videos from gun-toting veterans on Parler claiming that Black Lives Matter was a terrorist organization designed to exterminate the white race, allowing these distinct platforms to generate support for ideologically differentiated but symbolically united versions of QAnon. These groups could be joined by decontextualized screenshots, or simply reinterpreted by other users—a YouTuber might, for example, use the theories of that gun-toting Parler user, just with less extreme language. User experiences allowed for a drawing together of the multi-pronged promotional strategies of QAnon, leveraging different communities to create a sprawling theory that housed many conflicting and contradictory ideas but still gave people the power to connect to one another and expand the movement. The decontextualized fringe—propagated across platforms—granted a plethora of resources for the reinterpretation and reinforcement of beliefs.

Routines: Bringing Conspiracies Offline

Douglas is mild-mannered. A combat veteran and independent business owner, the California resident is not easily overwhelmed by confrontation or calamity, weathering both slights against him and a global pandemic with the same cheery, devout resolve. Still, as we start talking over the phone, I cannot help but imagine a younger, more scattered man, someone who gets easily

caught up in the moment. It is with a nervous giddiness that he tells me about his work as a “prayer warrior,” one of the QAnons in the movement who has dedicated himself to giving the conspiracy theory religious purity, strength, and conscience. A long-hauler, he has been with Q for as long as it is been around, and his greatest contribution now comes in the form of a weekly prayer meeting, which he tells me attracts people from over 29 countries. The prayer meeting, termed Bended Knee, has even attracted the attention of former National Security Advisor General Mike Flynn, who placed Bended Knee in his Twitter bio before his account was suspended. As Douglas describes it,

There’s nothing political to it other than getting people to take a few minutes to seek God. . . It’s about humanity and the good parts of humanity. And it’s not about trying to proselytize people, to become, you know, one particular type of follower. . . When I read the Bible, it says that all those who seek me with their whole heart will find me. And so that’s what Bended Knee was about, was simply to try to place the question in people’s minds and hearts to seek Him and let Him do the rest.

Three minutes, once a week, the question is placed in people’s minds. In Douglas’s words, that question remains primarily about the Lord, but in tweets about Bended Knee, there seems to be some greater specificity, as people request that others pray for Q, Donald Trump, and the end of child trafficking. For the already religious—which is a significant number of QAnon supporters—another prayer may be no great change in behavior, but it is one notable way in which QAnon doesn’t just stop with the internet. Instead, numerous journalists have documented the rise of both online and offline QAnon church services where pastors merge the gospel of Q with Christian writings, bringing the Biblical battle between good and evil to the arena of politics all the more clearly (Argentino n.d.; Burke 2020). Douglas still attends church (in-person when he can), and there he tries to be gentle in discussing Q—he knows not everyone is open to its ideas. Despite living in a blue county that has only gotten more Democratic in recent years, Douglas does not know many Democrats—and the ones he does know seem much more rational in person than those people online. Perhaps the filter bubble extends to the offline world—no need for algorithmic sorting—and perhaps the social media prism has distorted Douglas’s sense of what a Democrat is supposed to be—namely, someone in bed with Satan. What Douglas does know is that in his everyday life, he is going to continue practicing what Q has taught to him, even if that means defying state COVID-19 guidelines to keep his waste management business operational.

Douglas's weekly prayer group, subtle church proselytization, and COVID-19 defiance are just a few examples of how QAnon's online ideas and practices become baked into people's everyday lives. Douglas, much like other QAnons I spoke with, has leveraged social technology to form an ideology about the social world which is then translated into offline habits like mask mandate defiance. They have also integrated social technology into their interactions and engagements with other people in the offline world. Jared, one of few Swedish QAnons, described to me how at work he had tried bringing up QAnon with some of his coworkers. At first, they did not quite know what he was saying—and in part he struggled to explain it in its entirety—but he decided to instead send them some videos that he had found. While one coworker was still reluctant, another coworker was interested and asked for even more information. With the assistance of social media, Jared successfully got another person involved in QAnon.

There are numerous, minute ways that QAnon has wrapped itself into people's offline lives, many of which owe themselves to the particular affordances of algorithms and user experiences that we have discussed before; take, for instance, cell phone notifications. Notifications act as a perpetual reminder of QAnon's existence, and if one is subscribed to certain topical news channels or frequent content creators, then it is entirely possible that the notifications they receive are about current events, making the QAnon interpretation from a YouTube video or Facebook post the first interpretation of the event they receive. Roughly speaking, there are three ways that QAnon has been incorporated into routines that have helped mainstream the conspiracy theory's beliefs: hobbyist participation, interpersonal engagement and proselytization, and activism.

For many members of QAnon, participation has become something of a hobby or pastime, as they produce TikTok and YouTube videos, design graphics, and create merchandise. The presence of QAnon in their daily activities has definitely attracted the attention of friends and family, who wonder what they are up to or assist them with some of their tasks. The immense technological infrastructure of QAnon dispersed across different social media platforms requires that, for many members, participation becomes habitual. Checking for posts from Q, reading through Twitter and Facebook, and bingeing the latest documentaries gives structure not only to their days but also to their worlds, as QAnon has become an essential interpretive framework for understanding their lives. In interpersonal engagements, QAnon promotional material became the fodder for conversations, as we saw with Jared, and communication via QAnon content sustained relationships between QAnons and generated relationships between QAnons and non-QAnons, allowing for a skillful proselytization in the sharing of QAnon

content. A number of interviewees reflected this sentiment; in trying to keep up with friends during the lonely pandemic, they exchanged memes and news articles, either advertising QAnon or being advertised it. Finally, QAnons knew that the movement needed increased offline visibility, which resulted in mass protests, marches, and, in rare cases, acts of violence (Sommer 2020). Facebook events allowed for the coordination of offline events, and Facebook livestreams of such events often acted as a link between the two worlds: vicariously, people all around the world could participate in QAnon's offline world.

The perpetual immersion in QAnon digital culture structured people's engagements with politics and their friends, families, and coworkers. In each moment that they responded to QAnon group chats, sat down to eat in front of the latest YouTube video from a QAnon promoter, or discussed QAnon with a relative, they reified QAnon as a part of their life that transcended chats and memes but became the essence of political thought and sometimes interpersonal relationships. The offline world, too, allowed for prismatic encounters: Jared worked out ideas with coworkers in order to propagate and reinterpret his beliefs, while Douglas reinforced them in weekly prayer.

Conclusion

Immediately following the 2020 presidential election, the nation was further bifurcated by fears of voter fraud as politicians were forced to take hardline positions about the validity of mail-in ballots. QAnons had long been anticipating a "stolen election," in part because they had initially anticipated a Republican landslide, and so to hedge their bets, if Trump lost they needed a viable excuse for why he did not take nearly every state as was predicted. Q was inactive, leaving it to the acephalous network of conspiracy theorists—many of whom were flaunting bans on major platforms—to provide interpretations of Trump's struggles as the counts progressed. Taking cues from the former president, they settled on voter fraud. In return, Facebook was greeted with one of the fastest-growing groups of all time—"Stop the Steal," created by former Tea Party PAC promoters (Frenkel 2020). QAnon quickly capitalized on the group, and within hours of its creation, news articles from *The Epoch Times* and videos from QAnon promoters had made their way into the litany of theories being proposed to discredit the election. #StopTheSteal, originally the work of Trump operative and occasional QAnon endorser Roger Stone, began trending across social media, and posts were rife with conversations that could lead readers back to Satanism and Democratic pedophiles (Atlantic Council's Digital Forensic Research Lab 2021). Protests were organized around the country, and the conspiracy theorists joined in

arms and ideas with members of far-right militia groups and devout Trump supporters, eventually resulting in the January sixth storming of the Capitol.

This incident sums up nicely the very strategies we saw QAnon employ to spread its beliefs to the mainstream: followers leverage current events to push a false narrative that was connected to its broader beliefs about Satanism and child trafficking which were masked by decontextualizing information and spreading the work across a variety of platforms. Algorithms fed this narrative and showed it to others, who used different platforms to accelerate its response, and, reaching a breaking point, they took their beliefs into the offline world. However, it also points to the difficulties and oversights of this article. First, as has been discussed, without in-depth interviews, and even then, without experimental or archival data tracking how people respond to algorithmically-produced data, it will always be impossible to see how people actually interacted with the algorithm, though it may be appropriate to generalize trends on the basis of the algorithm itself, as it does aggregate social data that would suggest people have been associating certain ideas with one another.

The other limitations come from QAnon itself: as a movement with increasing parity between its beliefs and mainstream conservative beliefs, some of which were being propagated by the former president and popular TV hosts like Tucker Carlson or Sean Hannity, it is not entirely accurate to call some of QAnon's beliefs fringe. The conspiracy was capacious enough to both hide and promote its brand of conspiratorial white supremacy, and it was fragmented enough to hold contradictory values at once. Moreover, while QAnon was largely acephalous, it is known that it gained support from organizations such as Stone's Stop the Steal or Russian media and bots (Frenkel 2020; Menn 2020). The result of this is a gestalt QAnon, a conspiracy theory and political movement that leveraged social technology and was leveraged by outside actors, state authorities, and mainstream media to generate particular feelings about the world. How much of QAnon's successful mainstreaming can be attributed to its parity with Trump versus outside manipulation versus its leveraging of social technology is difficult, if not impossible, to determine. However, questions of quantity are not questions of character, and this article has aimed to lay out the character of QAnon's relationship to social technology.

Moving forward, these three concepts help to acknowledge the multi-faceted roles of algorithms in connecting, promoting, and distancing groups from one another. Moreover, they pay specific attention to how platforms are used in practice—as platforms change, the types of social interactions they allow will as well. This article dedicated a great deal of space to TikTok, an app that did not exist a few years ago and then played an instrumental role in

promoting disinformation that adapted to its affordances. While researchers have long acknowledged that we do not simply set our phones down and let the internet disappear from our minds, we should always be focusing on technology in its use, how it translates into everyday behavior, refracting and reflecting ourselves.

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Note

1. I have published an in-depth account of the ethical challenges I faced on a public website dedicated to ethnographic methods (Forberg 2021).

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